

# Lesson Plan: Skimming and Scanning

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## Lesson Information

**Course:** Academic Reading

**Learner Level:** Intermediate English Language Learners

**Class Length:** Approximately 65 minutes

**Topic:** Skimming and Scanning

**Reading Focus:** Reading efficiently to locate main ideas and specific information

## Learning Objectives

By the end of the lesson, students will be able to:

1. Explain the difference between skimming and scanning.
2. Skim a text to identify its topic, main idea, organization, and overall purpose.
3. Scan a text to locate specific facts, names, dates, numbers, and keywords.
4. Choose an appropriate reading strategy based on the purpose of a reading task.
5. reflect on how skimming and scanning can improve reading speed and comprehension.

## Materials

- Projector or board
- Short academic or informational reading passage
- Timer
- Skimming and scanning practice worksheet
- Highlighters or colored pens
- Exit ticket

## Key Vocabulary

- **Skimming:** Reading quickly to understand the general meaning or main idea of a text.
- **Scanning:** Reading quickly to locate a specific piece of information.
- **Main idea:** The most important message in a text.
- **Keyword:** An important word that helps readers locate information.
- **Heading:** A title that introduces a section of a text.

## Lesson Procedure

### 1. Warm-Up: How Do You Read? — 5 Minutes

Display or ask the following questions:

- Do you always read every word of a text?
- How do you find a specific word on a webpage?
- How do you decide whether an article is useful before reading it completely?
- When do you read something very quickly?

Students discuss the questions with a partner for two minutes. Invite several students to share their answers.

Explain that strong readers do not always read every word. They adjust their reading strategy depending on their purpose.

## 2. Introduction to Skimming and Scanning — 8 Minutes

Write the following two questions on the board:

1. What is this text mostly about?
2. What year did the event happen?

Ask students whether they would read a text in the same way to answer both questions.

Introduce the two strategies:

### Skimming

Skimming means reading quickly to understand the overall meaning of a text.

Readers often look at:

- The title
- Headings and subheadings
- Pictures and captions
- The introduction
- The first and last sentence of each paragraph
- Repeated words or ideas
- The conclusion

Skimming can help readers identify:

- The topic
- The main idea
- The writer's purpose
- The organization of the text

### Scanning

Scanning means moving quickly through a text to find one specific piece of information.

Readers often search for:

- Names
- Dates
- Numbers
- Places
- Definitions
- Capitalized words
- Keywords from a question

Explain that students do not need to understand every sentence when they scan.

## 3. Teacher Modeling: Skimming — 8 Minutes

Display a short reading passage without allowing students to read it closely.

Model the skimming process aloud:

1. Read the title.
2. Look at the headings.
3. Notice repeated words.
4. Read the first sentence of each paragraph.
5. Read the final sentence or conclusion.
6. Predict the main idea.

Use a think-aloud such as:

*“The title mentions renewable energy. I also see the words solar, wind, electricity, and environment several times. The first paragraph introduces energy problems, and the final paragraph discusses future solutions. I think the text explains how renewable energy can help communities.”*

Ask students:

- What is the topic?
- What is the likely main idea?
- What type of text is this?
- What information helped you make your prediction?

Emphasize that skimming is fast and purposeful.

#### 4. Guided Skimming Practice — 8 Minutes

Give students a new short text.

Tell students they will have only one minute to skim it. They should not read every word.

Students answer:

1. What is the text mainly about?
2. What is the writer’s main purpose?
3. Which statement best expresses the main idea?
4. How is the text organized?
5. Which words or features helped you understand the text?

Students compare answers with a partner.

Review the answers as a class and ask students to explain which parts of the text they examined.

#### 5. Teacher Modeling: Scanning — 7 Minutes

Display a timetable, advertisement, short article, menu, or informational passage.

Ask a specific question, such as:

*“How many students participated in the study?”*

Model the scanning process:

1. Identify the keyword in the question.
2. Predict what the answer may look like.
3. Move your eyes quickly down the page.
4. Look for numbers or related words.
5. Stop when you locate the relevant section.

6. Read only the sentence around the answer carefully.

Explain that readers should not begin at the first word and read every sentence.

Model another example:

*“The question asks for a year, so I am looking for a four-digit number. I see 2018, 2021, and 2024. Now I will read the words around those dates to identify the correct answer.”*

## 6. Scanning Challenge — 8 Minutes

Give students a passage containing several names, dates, numbers, and facts.

Students work individually and have three minutes to answer questions such as:

1. In what year did the program begin?
2. How many people participated?
3. Where was the study conducted?
4. Who organized the project?
5. What percentage of participants completed the program?
6. What was the final result?

Tell students to circle the keyword in each question before scanning the passage.

Students compare answers with a partner and identify where each answer appeared in the text.

## 7. Skimming or Scanning? — 6 Minutes

Read the following situations aloud. Students hold up one finger for skimming and two fingers for scanning.

1. You want to know whether an article is relevant to your research.
2. You need to find the departure time of a bus.
3. You want to understand the general argument of a chapter.
4. You need to find a professor’s email address.
5. You want to identify the topic of a news article.
6. You need to find the price of an item on a webpage.
7. You want to decide which section of a textbook you should read.
8. You need to locate a definition in a long passage.

After each response, ask one student to explain the reason for the choice.

## 8. Combined Reading Task — 10 Minutes

Give students a longer informational or academic passage.

### Part A: Skimming

Students have two minutes to answer:

1. What is the topic?
2. What is the main idea?
3. What is the writer’s purpose?
4. What are the main sections of the text?

## Part B: Scanning

Students answer specific questions about:

- A date
- A name
- A location
- A percentage
- A cause
- A result

Students must underline or highlight the part of the text containing each answer.

Review the answers as a class. Discuss how students changed their reading behavior between Part A and Part B.

## 9. Exit Ticket and Reflection — 5 Minutes

Students complete the following statements:

1. Skimming is useful when I need to \_\_\_\_\_.
2. Scanning is useful when I need to \_\_\_\_\_.
3. One difference between skimming and scanning is \_\_\_\_\_.
4. One strategy I will use during my next reading assignment is \_\_\_\_\_.

Collect the responses to check students' understanding.

## Assessment

### Formative Assessment

The teacher will monitor students through:

- Partner discussions
- Responses during teacher modeling
- Skimming practice questions
- Scanning challenge answers
- Participation in the strategy-identification activity
- Highlighted evidence in the combined reading task

### Exit Ticket Assessment

Students successfully meet the lesson objectives when they can:

- Accurately explain the difference between skimming and scanning
- Identify the main idea through skimming
- Locate specific information through scanning
- Select the correct strategy for a given reading purpose

## Differentiation

### Support for Lower-Level Learners

- Use shorter passages with clear headings.
- Bold important names, dates, and numbers during the first practice activity.

- Provide sentence frames such as:
  - “The text is mainly about \_\_\_\_\_.”
  - “I found the answer by looking for the keyword \_\_\_\_\_.”
- Allow students to work with a partner.
- Preteach unfamiliar vocabulary that is essential for understanding the topic.

### Extension for Higher-Level Learners

- Use longer passages with fewer visual clues.
- Ask students to create their own scanning questions.
- Ask students to identify the writer’s tone or purpose through skimming.
- Require students to explain why certain distractor answers are incorrect.
- Ask students to compare how efficiently they completed the task using different reading strategies.

### Homework

Students select an online article or textbook passage and complete the following:

1. Write the title of the text.
2. Spend no more than two minutes skimming it.
3. Write the topic and main idea.
4. Create five scanning questions.
5. Answer the questions and identify the keywords that helped locate each answer.
6. Write two sentences explaining which strategy was easier and why.

### Teacher Reflection

After the lesson, consider:

- Were students able to avoid reading every word?
- Could students clearly distinguish between skimming and scanning?
- Which strategy was more difficult for students?
- Did the time limits help students read more efficiently?
- What additional modeling or practice will students need?